and such. For instance, it is this group which first conceived of a need for an IT platform to aid the vaccination drive following the prime minister's advice. They later passed down the mandate to the Empowered Group to upscale one already in place—Electronic Vaccine Intelligence Network (eVIN), which was then converted to CoWIN with significant upgrades. Essentially, NEGVAC acted like a body for practical churning on all issues which were likely to come up in India's vaccination journey.

As mentioned above, conversations with vaccine manufacturers were now handled by NEGVAC. With several vaccines around the world making progress and showing encouraging results, pre-orders were rolling in. By mid-August, the wealthy nations had begun to pre-order many vaccines in quantities far more than required for their populations. The US had secured 800 million doses of at least six vaccines in development, with an option to purchase around one billion more. The UK, becoming the world's highest per-capita buyer, purchased around five doses of various vaccines for every citizen. The EU nations were buying vaccines as a group and Japan too locked down millions of doses of vaccines for itself. This resulted in potential vaccine manufacturers already packed to capacity with orders from wealthy nations for doses which may not even be used and as a result other countries were left scrambling to secure doses even for vulnerable groups.[4]

While NEGVAC continued its engagement with foreign manufacturers, it became clear that Moderna and Pfizer were not willing to spare the kind of large quantities required by India within the time frame we were looking at: late 2020, early-mid 2021. On the contrary, they were willing to offer measly doses at expensive prices—ranging from $20–25. Despite that, NEGVAC continued to hold talks with them in order to work out a way to procure as many doses as possible and also pushing the possibility of a technology transfer model so that we could manufacture the volumes required domestically. With Sputnik, too, which was jointly developed by the Russian Direct Investment Fund and Gamaleya National Research Institute of Epidemiology and Microbiology, they began discussion on procurement of doses, leading to an advanced discussion on transferring technology to an Indian manufacturer in order to achieve scale. On similar lines, they also began to hold discussions with Johnson & Johnson, who was also in the process of developing a single-dose vaccine candidate which also led to similar conclusions—that unless we would manufacture it